The singing staircase

Lesson 1 · listen, sing and feel the pulse

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For: ages 8 to 12, the whole class. **Length:** 50 minutes.

What they learn: to hear pitch, to sing a note and to feel the pulse.

What you need: a computer with speakers and, if available, a projector. **No music knowledge needed:** the keyboard and the tuner do the work; you guide.

Before the lesson (5 minutes, at home): open the Cosmic Keyboard, press `Z` `X` `C` `V` `B` `N` `M` and listen to the scale from C to B. Open the tuner and sing a note to see how it shows it.

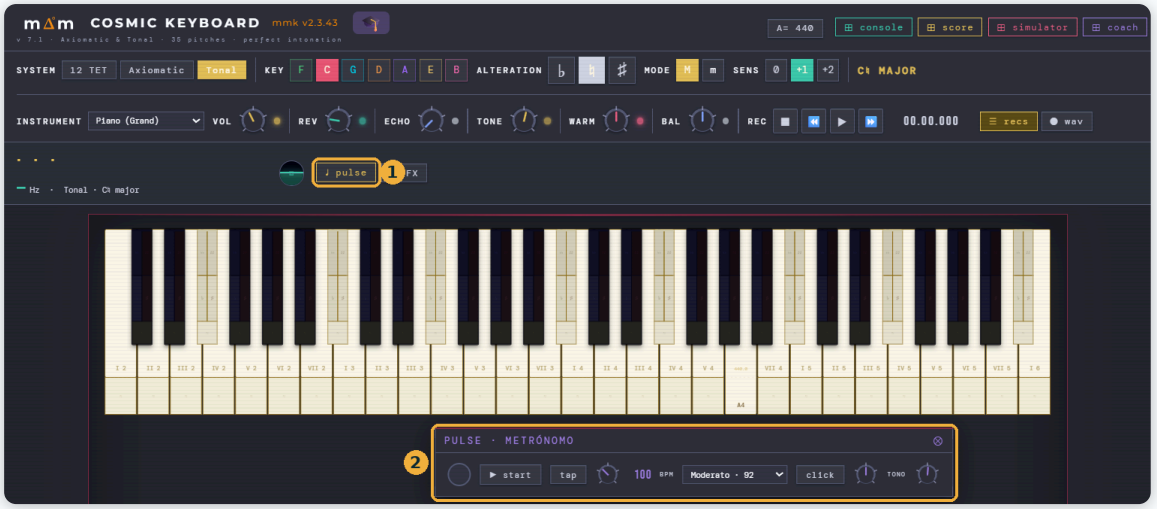
Before you start: the pulse

What is the pulse?

The pulse is the steady heartbeat of music: always the same distance apart, like the tick-tock of a clock or footsteps when walking. When we clap along to a song, we are clapping the pulse. Everyone who plays or sings together follows the same pulse.

The **metronome** is the machine that marks that beat with a light and a sound, so the class stays together. Its speed is measured in **BPM**, beats per minute: **60 BPM = one beat per second**. More BPM, faster.

Where to find it in the Cosmic Keyboard



1. **Open the metronome:** press the **pulse** button (1), the one with a little musical note, in the third row from the top, next to **FX**.
2. The **PULSE · METRONOME** panel (2) appears below the keyboard.



3. **Choose the tempo** (the speed of the pulse). The easiest way: press **tap** several times in a row, at the speed you want; the metronome measures it and shows the **BPM**. You can also turn the **knob** next to tap: it raises or lowers the BPM, and the list shows the musical name of that tempo (for example *Andante · 76* or *Moderato · 92*). Or pick a tempo straight from the list. To begin, go slow: about **60 BPM**.
4. **Start it** with **start**. The **light** (the circle) flashes on every beat.
5. **To hear it,** switch on **click**. The two knobs on the right adjust the click: the first one, its **volume**; the **TONE** knob, whether it sounds higher or lower.
6. **To close it,** press ⊗, at the top right of the panel.

The lesson, step by step

1 Listening with the body

10 min

On the right of the Keyboard is the **RECORDINGS** list (if you can't see it, press ☰ **recs**). Press ▶ on Bach's "Sinfonia No. 1". Listen three times, each time with a task:

1. **March on the spot** with the pulse.
2. **Draw the melody in the air** with your hand: when it goes up, the hand goes up; when it goes down, the hand goes down.
3. **"We're home!"**: when the music sounds as if it has arrived home (an ending that rests), everyone stands up.

"How did you feel? What did this music make you want to do?"

There are no wrong answers: each child can answer with a word or a gesture.

2 The staircase

10 min

Play `Z` `X` `C` `V` `B` `N` `M` slowly, one key at a time. The class sings each note on a long "ah". Then from the top down.

3 The echo

10 min

You play one key of the staircase; the class sings it. Then two keys in a row, then three. A pupil comes up to play and the class answers.

4 The tuner

10 min

A pupil sings a long note in front of the computer, with the tuner open. Everyone sees the name of the note being sung. Repeat with others.

"Who can sing exactly the same note as the keyboard?"

5 The pulse

10 min

Open the metronome (**pulse**), set a slow tempo with **tap**, press **start** and switch on **click** (see "Before you start: the pulse"). The class claps the pulse while you play the staircase, one key per beat. To finish, a volunteer plays the staircase alone, following the pulse.

The keys and their notes

QWERTY

Top · high notes

Q	W	E	R	T	Y	U
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

Middle

A	S	D	F	G	H	J
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

Bottom · low notes

Z	X	C	V	B	N	M
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

The three rows of the computer keyboard hold the same staircase, from C to B: the bottom row is the lowest and the top row the highest. The ← and → arrow keys change the octave: the whole staircase moves down or up.

Note names: *C = do · D = re · E = mi · F = fa · G = sol · A = la · B = si. Both names mean the same note.*

How to tell it worked: most of the class sings back a note that was played, and the class keeps the pulse with their claps through the whole staircase.

These lessons are a starting point. Each teacher can design the examples to suit their own class. For our part, we will keep adding lesson topics according to the requests we receive through the contact form.

✂ cut out and take home

Let's play with music at home

For parents · 10 minutes a week · no music knowledge needed

Today in class we learned to sing the notes of the keyboard. This week, play together:

Z	X	C	V	B	N	M
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

Each key on the bottom row is a note, from C (the first) to B (the seventh).

1. Open the keyboard on the computer: **musicmotionsuite.com/apps/mmk-demo.html**
2. **The echo:** one person plays a key between `Z` and `M`; the other sings it. Then swap.
3. **The tuner:** your child sings a long note in front of **tuner.mariomaurano.com** and looks at its name. Can they sing the same note as the keyboard?

The microphone only works on your computer: nothing is recorded or sent. No sign-up needed.

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